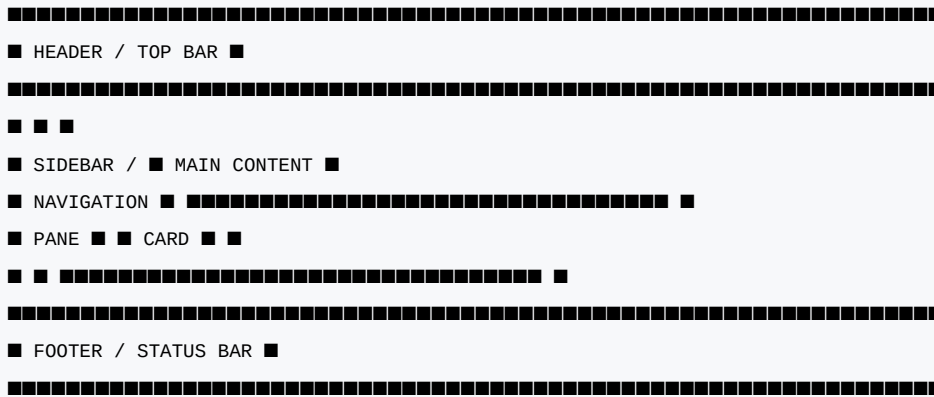


UI Terminology Guide

A practical reference for understanding the names of interface sections, controls, overlays, and layout patterns used in modern web and desktop applications.

A simplified UI anatomy



Core idea: UI vocabulary lets you describe what something is and what role it plays. This becomes useful when working with HTML/CSS, component-based frameworks, design systems, and developer documentation.

1. The Big Picture

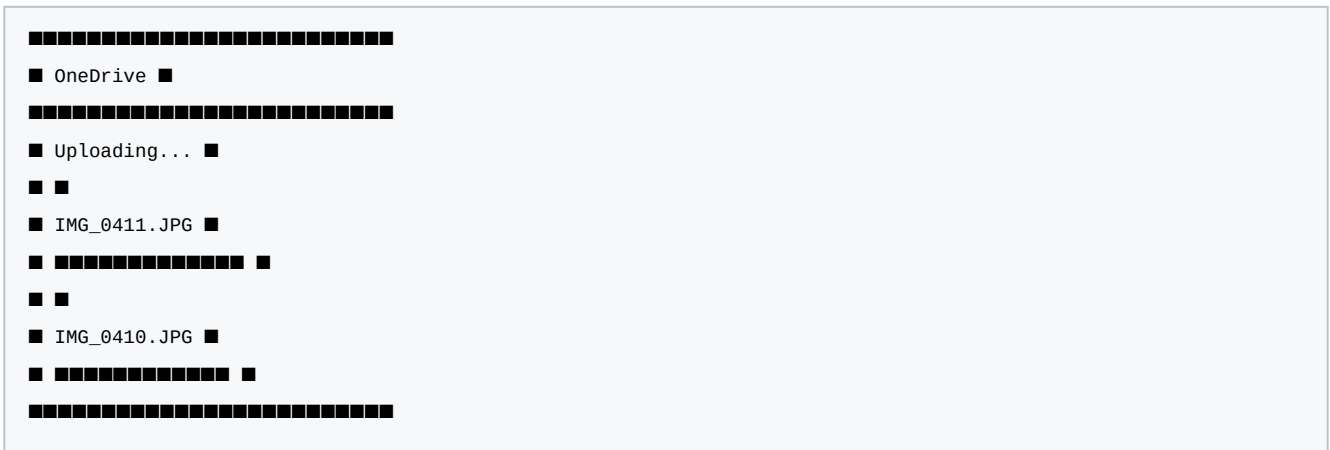
A user interface can be thought of as a collection of layout regions, navigation elements, controls, content components, feedback elements, and overlays.



There is no single universal naming system. Different products, design systems, and frameworks may use overlapping terms or define them differently.

2. Panel

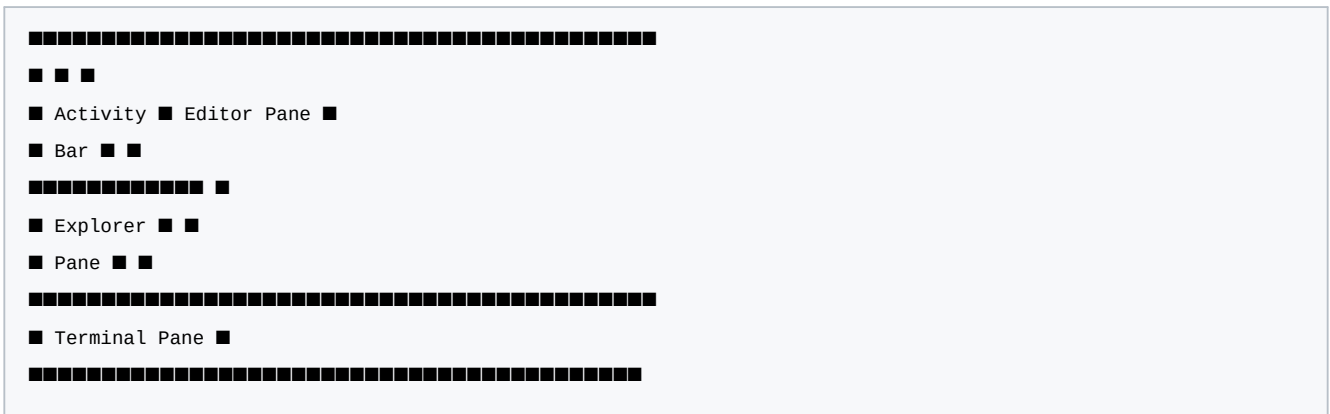
A panel is a distinct area containing related information or controls.



Settings panel, properties panel, details panel, sync panel, control panel.

3. Pane

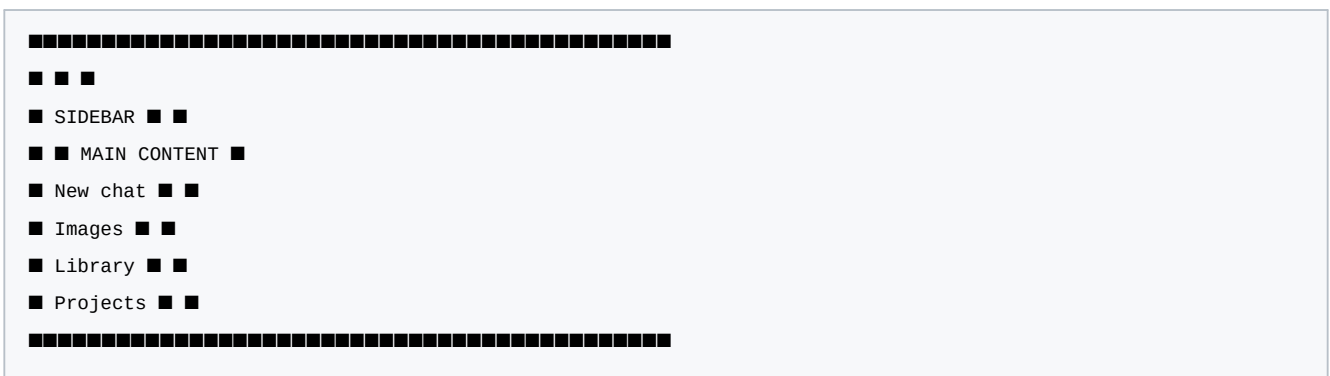
A pane is usually an area inside a larger application layout, often dedicated to a particular function.



VS Code uses panes for areas such as the editor, Explorer, and terminal.

4. Sidebar

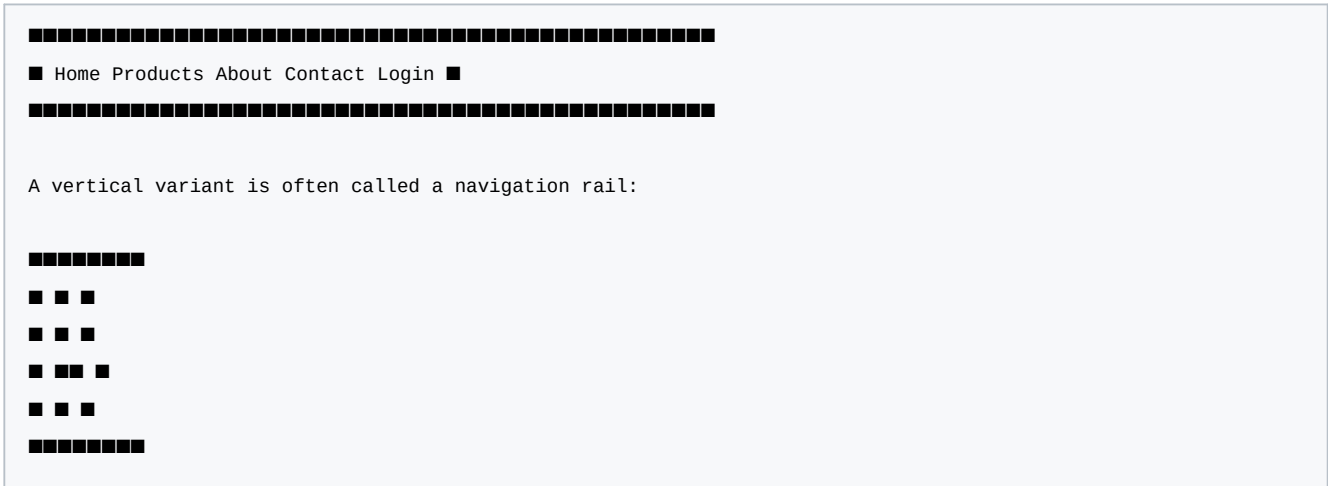
A sidebar is a vertical section, commonly placed on the left or right, often used for navigation or secondary tools.



Sidebars are common in websites, dashboards, editors, and productivity applications.

5. Navigation Bar / Navigation Rail

Navigation elements help the user move between major sections of an application or site.



Common terms include navbar, nav, navigation bar, navigation rail, and navigation sidebar.

6. Toolbar

A toolbar contains actions or tools that operate on the current context.



Example HTML structure:

```
Undo
Redo
Save
```

7. Header / Top Bar

The header or top bar is the upper region of an application or website. It often contains branding and navigation.



On websites, header is particularly common.

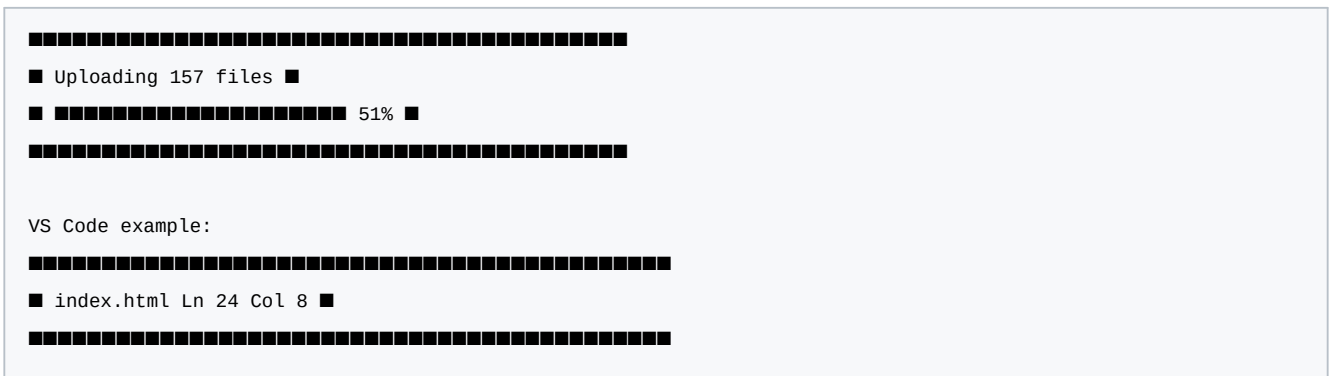
8. Footer

The footer is the lower region of a page and often contains secondary navigation, legal links, or copyright information.



9. Status Bar

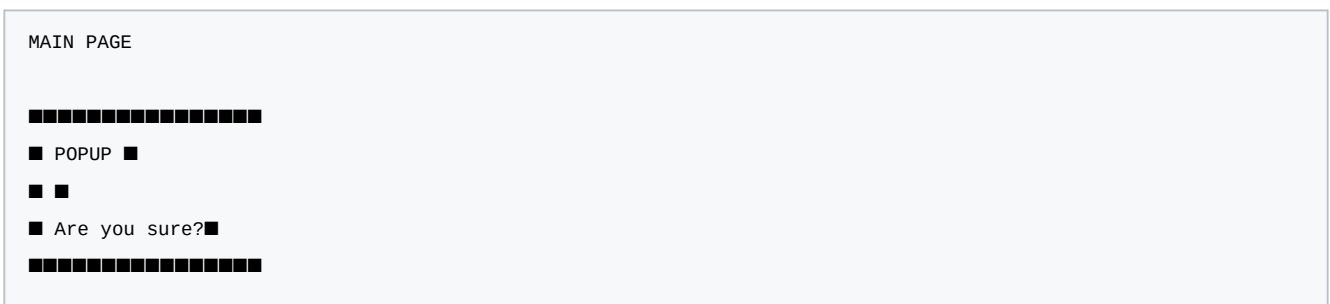
A status bar communicates the current state of an application or document.



A status bar tells you what is happening or where you are.

10. Popup

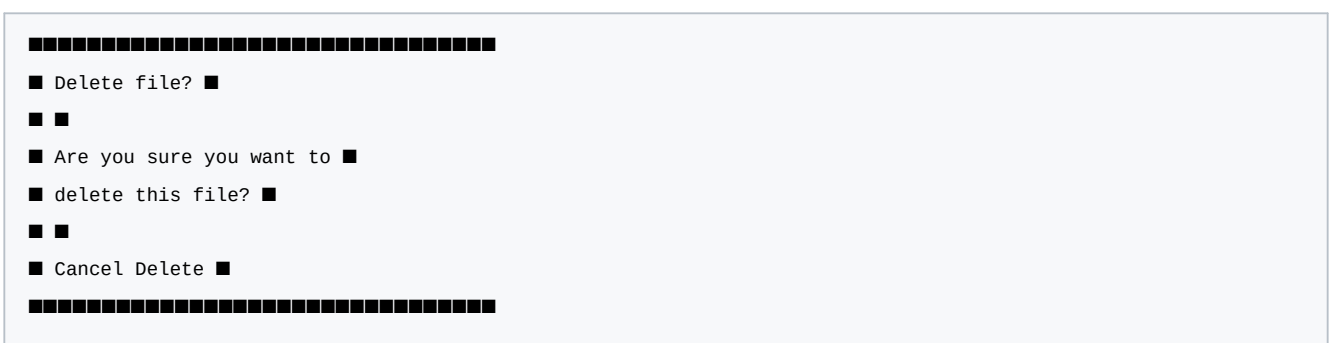
Popup is a broad, informal term for something that appears over or above the existing interface.



More precise terms such as dialog, popover, modal, or flyout may apply depending on behavior.

11. Dialog

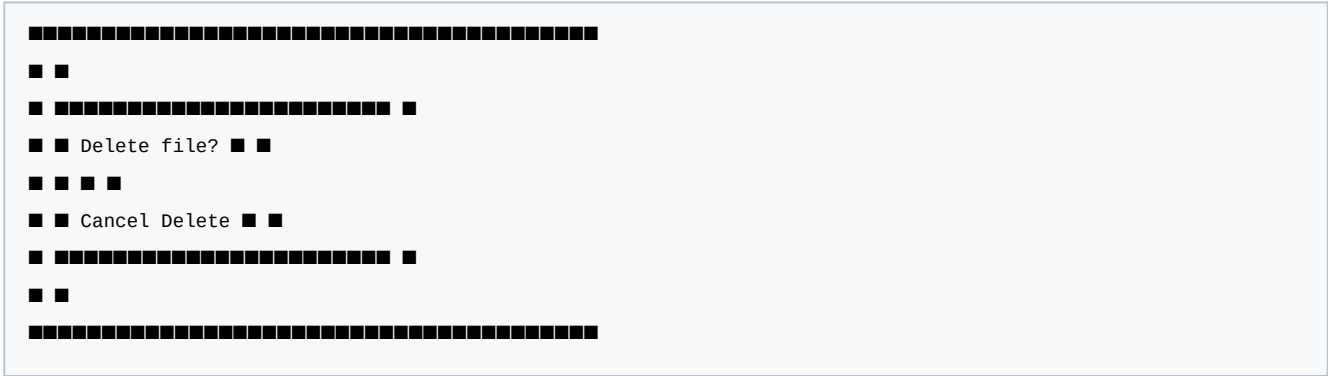
A dialog is a UI element that asks the user to make a decision or provide information.



A dialog can be modal or non-modal.

12. Modal

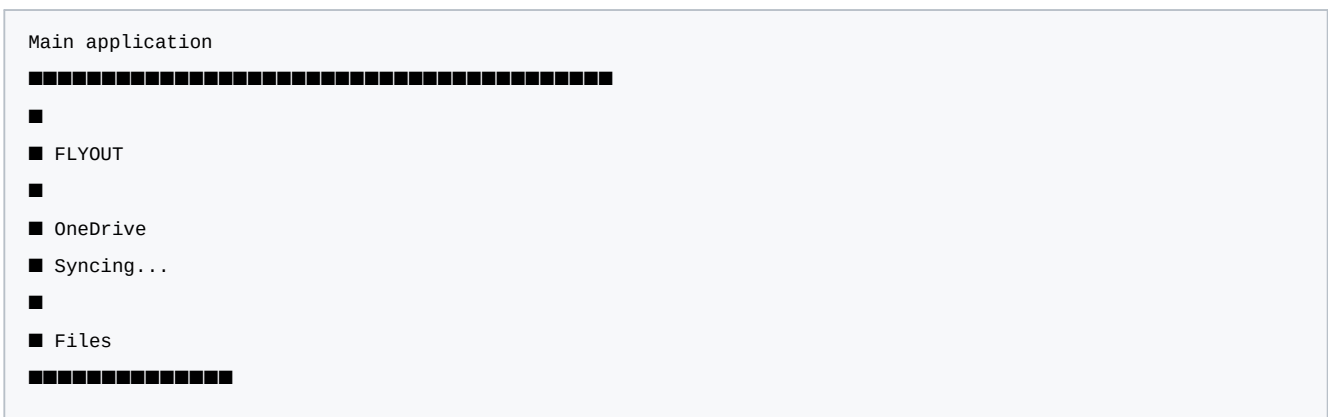
A modal takes focus away from the underlying interface, usually preventing interaction with the background until it is dismissed.



The darkened or blocked background is commonly called a scrim or backdrop.

13. Flyout

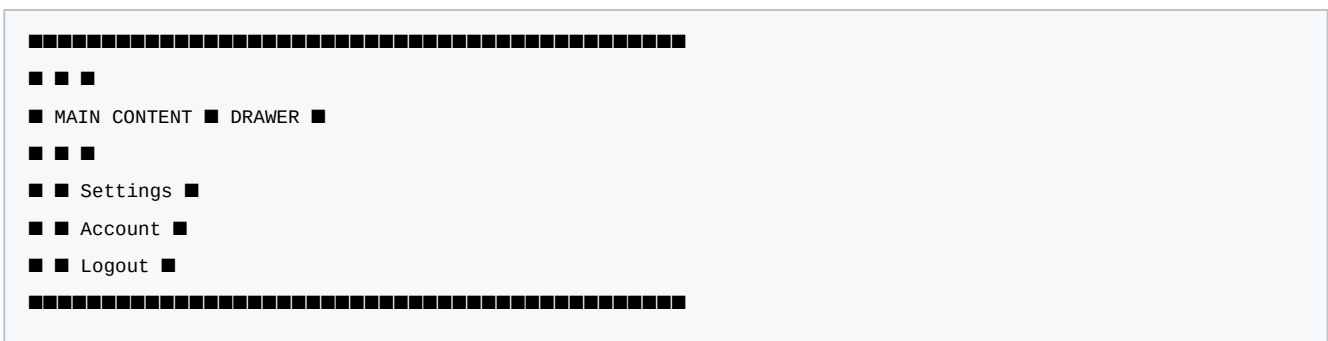
A flyout is a UI section that appears from an edge or from a control without replacing the entire page.



The OneDrive system-tray interface shown earlier can reasonably be described as a flyout or popup panel.

14. Drawer

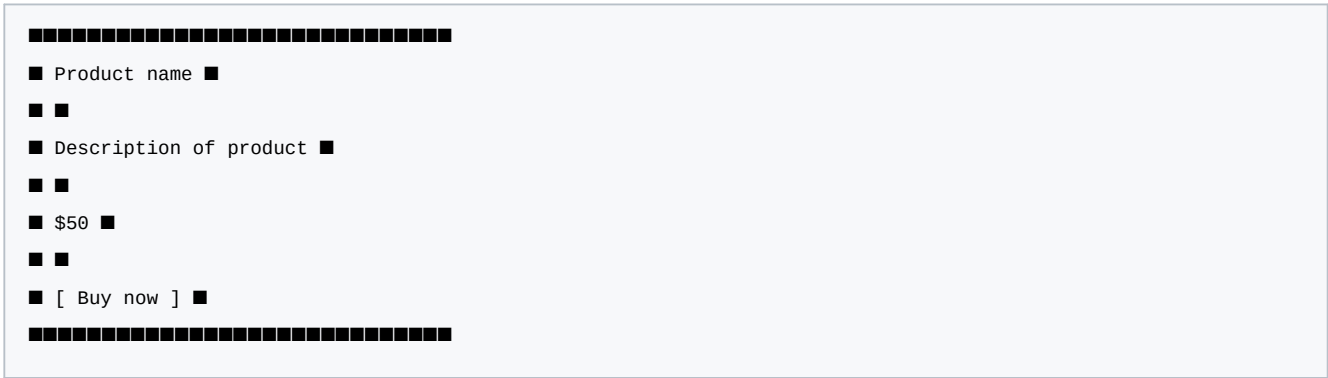
A drawer is a section that slides in from an edge, especially common in mobile interfaces.



A drawer often contains navigation, settings, or contextual information.

15. Card

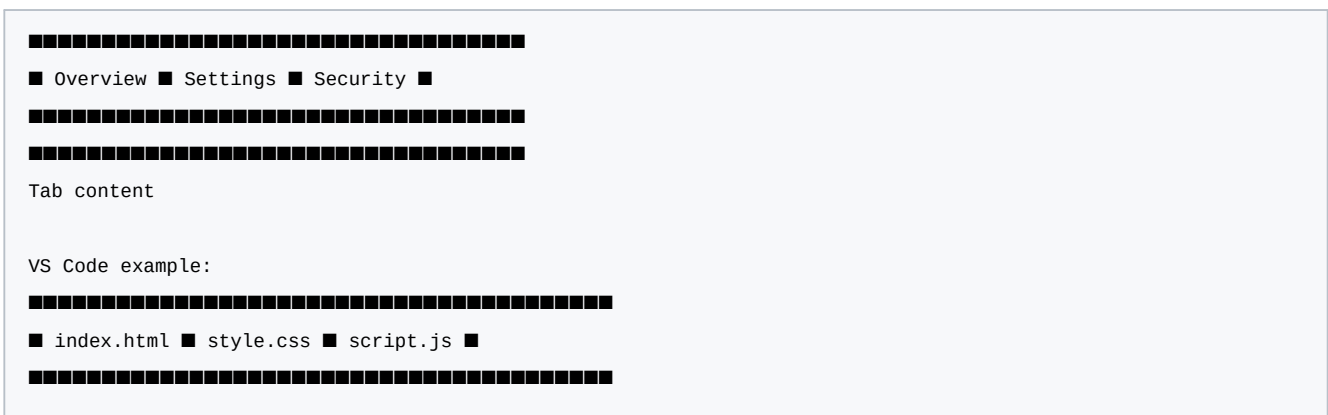
A card is a self-contained piece of content, often grouping related information and actions.



Cards are extremely common in modern web design.

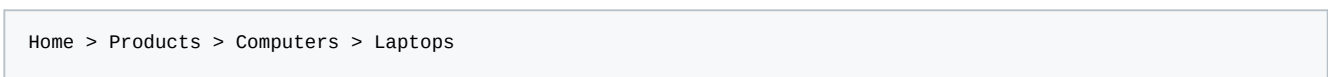
16. Tabs

Tabs let users switch between related views without leaving the current context.



17. Breadcrumb

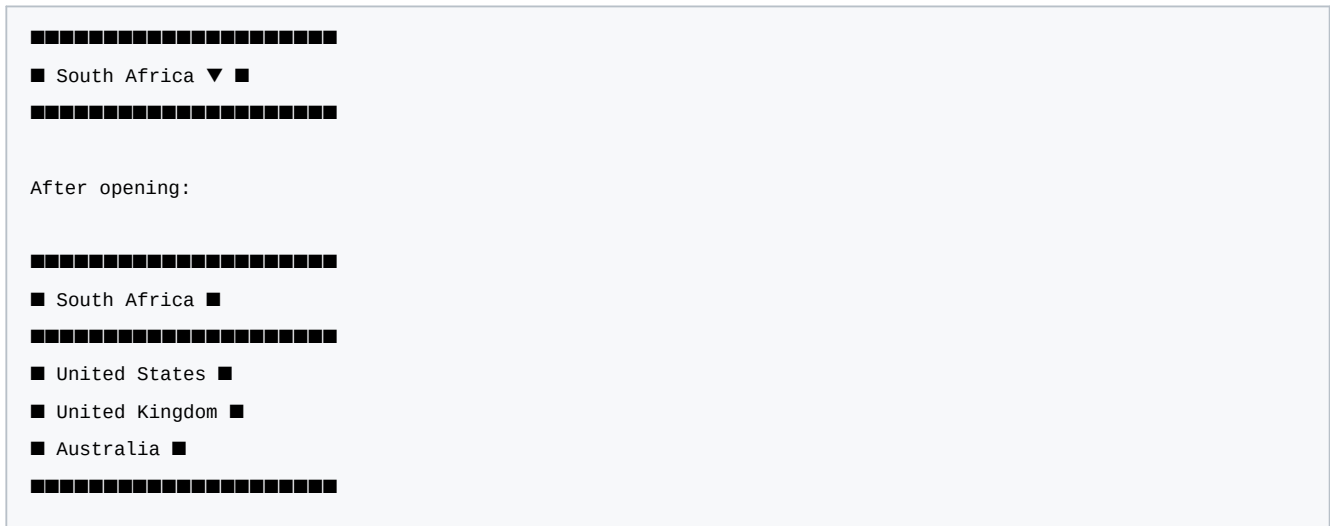
A breadcrumb shows where the user is within a hierarchy.



The name comes from the Hansel and Gretel idea of leaving breadcrumbs to find your way back.

18. Dropdown / Select

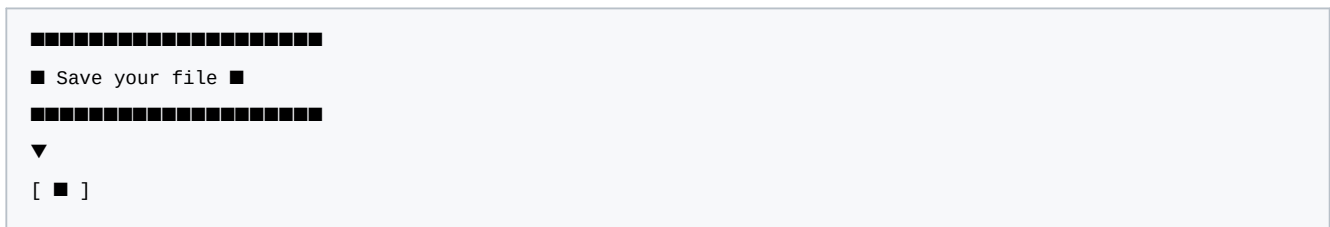
A dropdown or select lets the user choose from a list of options.



Depending on the implementation, you may also hear menu or listbox.

19. Tooltip

A tooltip is a small explanatory message that appears when the user hovers over or focuses on an element.



Tooltips are especially useful for icon-only controls.

20. A Practical Vocabulary Hierarchy

USER INTERFACE



Layout

Header

Sidebar

Main content

Footer



Navigation

Navbar

Navigation rail

Tabs

Breadcrumbs



Controls

Button

Checkbox

Radio button

Toggle

Dropdown

Input



Content

Card

List

Table

Image



Feedback

Alert

Toast

Tooltip

Progress bar

Status indicator



Overlays

Modal

Dialog

Popup

Popover

Flyout

Drawer

Remember: this is a vocabulary map, not a strict standard. Real-world products may use overlapping terms or define them differently.

21. Panel vs Pane vs Sidebar vs Drawer

These words overlap, so context matters. A useful rule of thumb is:

Term	Useful mental model
Panel	A distinct area containing related information or controls.
Pane	An area within a larger application layout, often one of several regions.
Sidebar	A vertical region, commonly left or right, often for navigation.
Drawer	A panel that slides in from an edge, often for mobile or contextual content.
Flyout	A temporary section that appears from a control or edge.

22. Layout, Component, and State

These three concepts are particularly useful when moving from plain HTML/CSS into component-based frontend development.

LAYOUT → Where something is.

Example: The sidebar is on the left.

COMPONENT → What something is.

Example: That is a navigation component.

STATE → What condition it is currently in.

Example: The OneDrive component is in a syncing state.

In React or similar frameworks, a page can be assembled from reusable components:

```

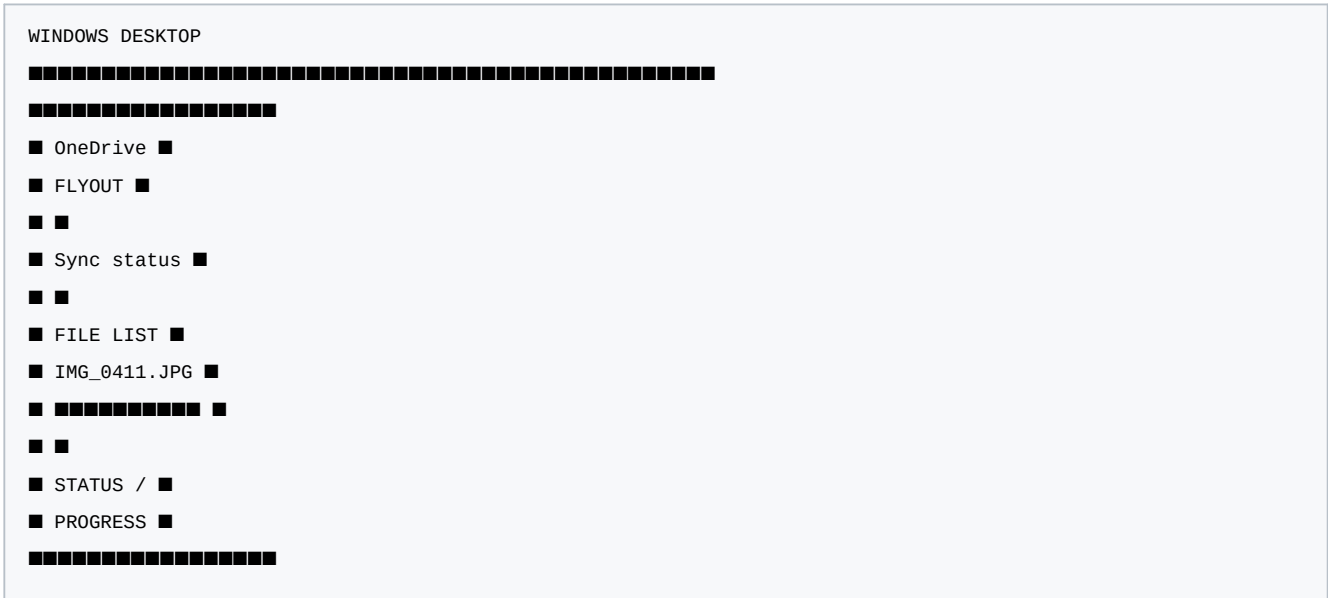
components/
  ■■■■ Navbar
  ■■■■ Sidebar
  ■■■■ Button
  ■■■■ Card
  ■■■■ Modal
  ■■■■ UserProfile
  ■■■■ Footer

App
  ■■■■ Navbar
  ■■■■ Sidebar
  ■■■■ Main
  ■■■■ Card
  ■■■■ Card
  ■■■■ Card

```

23. Putting It All Together: The OneDrive Example

The OneDrive interface from the earlier screenshot can be described using several of these terms at once.



Professional description: “The OneDrive system-tray flyout contains a sync-status panel showing upload progress and a list of files currently being synchronized.”

24. Quick Reference

Term	Meaning
Header / top bar	Top region of a page or app.
Sidebar	Vertical region, often for navigation.
Pane	Region inside a larger application layout.
Panel	Distinct area containing related information or controls.
Toolbar	Group of actions/tools.
Status bar	Communicates current state or position.
Card	Self-contained content block.
Tabs	Switch between related views.
Breadcrumb	Shows hierarchical location.
Dropdown / select	Choose an option from a list.
Tooltip	Small contextual explanation on hover/focus.
Dialog	Asks the user to interact or decide.
Modal	Takes focus and blocks the background.
Popover	Small contextual overlay near a trigger.
Flyout	Temporary section that appears from an edge/control.
Drawer	Panel that slides in from an edge.
Toast	Brief, usually non-blocking feedback message.
Progress bar	Shows progress toward a task.

Learning tip: When you see an unfamiliar interface, try naming its regions out loud: header, sidebar, main content, toolbar, card, status indicator, overlay, and so on. This habit makes UI screenshots, design mockups, HTML/CSS structures, and frontend documentation easier to understand.